THE CURLY CHEF

EGGLESS GOURMET COOKIE STICKS

Buttery • Delicately crisp • Dark chocolate dipped

A detailed professional recipe guide

French pâtisserie-inspired biscuit fingers
finished with bittersweet couverture and roasted pistachio

1. Recipe overview

Yield: approximately 30–35 sticks, depending on size
Preparation: 25–35 minutes
Chilling: 20–30 minutes
Baking: 14–19 minutes per tray (oven-dependent)
Finishing: 15–25 minutes, plus setting time
Skill level: intermediate home baker / entry-level professional

The goal is a slender, evenly baked butter biscuit with a delicate, short crumb. A portion is dipped in dark chocolate, then finished with a restrained garnish. This recipe is eggless and uses no raising agent.

2. Ingredients

A. Cookie dough

Ingredient	Weight	Purpose / note
Unsalted butter, softened	120 g	Main fat; pliable, not melted.
Icing sugar	55 g	Fine texture and gentle sweetness.
Cornflour (cornstarch)	25 g	Helps create a delicate, short bite.
Plain flour (maida)	155 g	Structure; weigh accurately.
Milk powder	15 g	Adds dairy flavour and supports browning.
Vanilla bean paste	4 g	Vanilla extract may substitute.
Fine salt	1.5 g	Balances sweetness.
Milk	10–15 g, as needed	Add gradually; absorption varies.

B. Chocolate coating & garnish

Ingredient	Amount	Notes
Dark couverture chocolate, 55–65%	180 g	Choose a chocolate with a flavour you enjoy.
Neutral oil or cocoa butter (optional)	5 g	For a thinner coating; oil softens the snap.
Roasted pistachios, finely chopped	As needed	Apply while chocolate is wet.
Raspberry powder / almond nibs / flaky salt	As needed	Optional alternatives; choose one or two.

Equipment

- Digital kitchen scale; mixing bowl; flexible spatula; small sieve.
- Piping bag and large round nozzle (or clean hands for rolling).
- Baking tray, parchment paper, oven thermometer if available.
- Stainless-steel bowl and spatula for chocolate; dipping tool; parchment-lined setting tray.

3. Detailed method

Step 1 — Prepare the oven and tray

Preheat to **160°C conventional** or **150°C fan**. Line a flat tray with parchment. Accurate oven temperature matters more than a fixed baking time.

Step 2 — Cream butter and icing sugar

Mix softened butter and icing sugar with a spatula or hand whisk for 2–3 minutes until smooth, creamy and slightly lighter. This is not cake batter: avoid whipping in lots of air, which can encourage spreading. Butter should yield when pressed but not look oily or melted.

Step 3 — Add flavour and dry enrichments

Mix in vanilla and salt. Add milk powder and cornflour; stir until evenly distributed. Scrape the sides and base so no pockets of dry ingredients remain.

Step 4 — Add the flour

Sift in the plain flour. Fold gently until the mixture starts to clump together. Stop as soon as no loose flour remains. Do not knead; excessive mixing can develop gluten and make the sticks tough.

Step 5 — Adjust the consistency

Add milk a little at a time, starting with 10 g. The dough should be soft enough to pipe through a large round nozzle while holding a line on the tray. For hand-rolling, it should form a smooth finger without crumbling. Do not add all the milk automatically.

Step 6 — Pipe or roll evenly

Transfer dough to a piping bag fitted with a large round nozzle. Press dough down to remove large air pockets. Pipe straight sticks about **8–9 cm long and 8–10 mm thick**, leaving space between them. Keep pressure steady and lift cleanly at the end. Alternatively, roll equal portions into fingers. Uniform thickness is essential.

Step 7 — Chill the shaped sticks

Refrigerate the tray for 20–30 minutes. Chilling firms the butter and helps the sticks retain their shape. If the dough is very soft, chill until pieces feel firmer to a light touch.

Step 8 — Bake

Bake for approximately **14–19 minutes**, checking early because slim biscuits can overbake quickly. Look for set surfaces and lightly golden edges; centres may remain paler. Avoid deep browning. Oven performance varies.

Step 9 — Cool completely

Leave the sticks on the tray until firm enough to move, then transfer carefully to a rack. They are fragile while hot and become crisper as they cool. Do not dip warm biscuits in chocolate; residual heat can melt the coating and trap moisture.

Step 10 — Prepare the chocolate

For a professional finish, temper couverture: melt dark chocolate to 45–50°C, cool to 27–28°C, then gently rewarm to a working temperature of 31–32°C. Stir gently and keep water away. For a simpler method, melt gently and mix in up to 5 g neutral oil; this makes dipping easier but gives a softer coating with less snap.

Step 11 — Dip and drain

Hold a cooled stick at one end and dip roughly one-third to one-half into the chocolate. Lift slowly and let excess chocolate drain back into the bowl. Rotate slightly for a clean boundary. Avoid a thick pool at the underside.

Step 12 — Garnish and set

Place dipped sticks on parchment. While the chocolate is wet, add a small pinch of finely chopped roasted pistachio, raspberry powder or another chosen garnish. Keep the finish restrained. Let properly tempered chocolate set in a cool room; otherwise chill briefly if needed.

4. Pastry-chef troubleshooting

Problem	Likely cause	Correction
Dough too stiff to pipe	Butter too cold, insufficient liquid, or excess flour.	Let dough soften slightly; mix in milk 2–3 g at a time.
Sticks spread or lose definition	Butter too warm, dough too soft, or insufficient chilling.	Chill longer; verify oven temperature and use pliable, not melted, butter.
Sticks are tough	Dough kneaded or overmixed after flour was added.	Fold only until combined; stop as soon as dough holds together.
Sticks break while handling	Moved while hot, too thin, or unevenly baked.	Cool fully until set; pipe slightly thicker and keep dimensions consistent.
Cookies are pale and soft after cooling	Underbaked, too thick, or excess moisture.	Bake 1–2 minutes longer at a time; cool fully before judging crispness.
Chocolate looks streaky or dull	Not tempered, overheated, or exposed to moisture.	Temper accurately and keep tools dry. Untempered chocolate may taste good but look less polished.
Coating is too thick	Chocolate too cool or viscous.	Bring tempered chocolate to working temperature; avoid excess oil.

5. Finishing variations

- **Dark chocolate + pistachio:** bittersweet, nutty and elegant.
- **Dark chocolate + freeze-dried raspberry:** fruity acidity balances the butter.
- **Dark chocolate + flaky salt:** a clean, grown-up flavour; use only a few flakes.
- **Chocolate drizzle:** dip one end, then drizzle a contrasting chocolate line after the base coat sets.

6. Storage and service

Allow chocolate to set fully before packing. Store in an airtight container in a cool, dry place, away from sunlight and strong odours. Humidity softens the biscuit and can spoil the finish. In a hot climate, if refrigeration is necessary, seal the container well and allow it to approach room temperature before opening to reduce condensation. Serve at room temperature.

7. Quality-control checklist

- Sticks are straight and uniform in length and thickness.
- Edges are lightly golden; centres are set and delicately crisp after cooling.
- The crumb is short and buttery, not chewy or floury.
- Chocolate has a clean boundary with no excess pooling.
- Garnish is dry, fresh and applied sparingly.
- No moisture touches the chocolate during melting or tempering.

Professional note: Oven behaviour, flour absorption and chocolate tempering vary. Use the visual and texture cues alongside the stated temperatures and times; they are more reliable than time alone.